Week 6 Notes: Surf, Folk Rock, Motown and Soul

Oct 6, 2026 · @Michael J

The 1960s, from the Week 6.1, 6.2 and 6.3 slides. No lecture recording: the transcript uploaded with the 6.1 slides was the Week 4.2 lecture again.

The Week's Frame

Week 6 covers four 1960s scenes: **surf, urban folk / folk rock, Motown, and soul**. Week 6.1 = surf, the Beach Boys and folk rock; 6.2 = urban folk, Bob Dylan and the electric guitar; 6.3 = soul, Motown and Aretha Franklin.

The thread connecting it to Week 5 is **production and the studio**. Week 5 ended with Phil Spector's Wall of Sound and the Wrecking Crew. Week 6.1 picks up exactly there: Brian Wilson takes the Spector approach, uses the same session players, and turns the studio itself into the instrument. The question running through the week is **who the author of a record is** — the band, the producer, or the session musicians.

On the midterm this week supplies **5 of the 20 songs**: "Surfin' U.S.A." and "Wouldn't It Be Nice" (both in these slides), plus "Subterranean Homesick Blues," "You Keep Me Hangin' On" and "Respect" (in slides you don't have yet).

Surf Music and Southern California (Week 6.1)

Surf music is tied to a place: **Southern California** — the beach, cars, surfboards, and white middle-class teenagers with leisure time. It's the postwar youth culture from Week 4, moved to the coast.

Surf was initially an instrumental genre. The slide examples:

Track	Artist	Year
"Walk, Don't Run"	The Ventures	1960 (re-recorded 1964)
"Misirlou"	Dick Dale	1962

The Ventures album cover shows the band holding Fender guitars and bass. The electric guitar *is* the voice in early surf — no singer needed. That's the Week 4 guitar-cultures material in a new setting: twangy, reverb-heavy, trebly electric guitar as the lead.

The Beach Boys are the next step: they put **vocals** on top of the surf sound.

The Beach Boys and "Surfin' U.S.A." (Week 6.1)

The Beach Boys' sound, per the slides:

- **A distinct, contrapuntal, falsetto-led vocal style** — several vocal lines moving independently, topped by a high falsetto
- **Multipart harmonies**
- **"Chuck Berry riffs" and trebly guitar timbres**
- **Lyrics: the beach, middle-class teenagers**

"Surfin' U.S.A." (1963) — *on the midterm song list*

- Based on **Chuck Berry's "Sweet Little Sixteen" → songwriting credit**
- **Production: Brian Wilson**
- **The "California Sound"**
- **Lyrics: reference to surfing spots**

The songwriting-credit point is the one to know. The melody comes from Berry's song. The slide says only "songwriting credit"; the standard history is that Berry's publisher challenged it and Berry was then credited. This is the same pattern as earlier weeks — a Black artist's song reworked into a white group's hit — except here the credit was eventually corrected. Compare "Hound Dog" (Thornton → Presley) and "That's All Right" (Crudup → Presley).

Label: Capitol (not on this slide, but the *Pet Sounds* cover on the next slides shows the Capitol logo, and the Beach Boys were on Capitol throughout this period).

Listen for: Berry's guitar intro, then the stacked harmonies and falsetto; a list of California and other surf spots in the lyric.

Brian Wilson, *Pet Sounds* and "Wouldn't It Be Nice" (Week 6.1)

1964: Brian Wilson stops touring and stays in the studio. The result is **increased complexity in songwriting** — the slide sets this alongside **the Beatles' *Rubber Soul* (1965)**, as the two bands pushed each other.

***Pet Sounds* (1966)**

- **One of the first "concept" albums** — an album as one connected work, not a set of singles
- **Studio experimentation:** overdubbing, mixing, ***looping** (asterisked on the slide), unusual instruments, **theremin**
- **Brian and the "Spector sound"** — the direct link back to Week 5
- **Financial success *versus* critical success** — *Pet Sounds* was a critical landmark but not the commercial hit the earlier surf records were

"Brian Wilson's puppets?" The slide shows a *Melody Maker* article from November 12, 1966, asking whether the touring Beach Boys were merely puppets of "sound genius" Brian Wilson. Carl Wilson's answer, in short: no — Brian plays the major creative role, but everyone contributes. The headline is the week's authorship question in one line: if one person writes and produces everything in the studio, what are the band members on stage?

"Wouldn't It Be Nice" (1966) — *on the midterm song list*

- **Single from *Pet Sounds***
- **"Wall of Sound" (orchestral)** — Spector's technique
- **Key change indicative of classical music**
- **Overdubbed voices (to Brian's specification)**
- **The Wrecking Crew** — the same Los Angeles session players from Spector's records in Week 5

Label: Capitol (the *Pet Sounds* cover shows it).

Listen for: a harp-like, chiming intro; dense layered orchestral backing; stacked overdubbed vocals; a mid-song change of key and tempo. Contrast with "Surfin' U.S.A." — three years apart, but one is a guitar-band surf song and the other is a studio production.

Why it matters. The Week 4.2 lecture said that bands like the Beatles and Beach Boys would "expand the world of what recorded music is, in part due to new technologies in the studio" — the shift from rock 'n' roll to rock. *Pet Sounds* is that shift. Music made in the studio, often impossible to reproduce live.

Folk Rock (Week 6.1)

"Folk rock" = traditional folk + rock instrumentation.

It came out of two things meeting: **the British Invasion + the urban folk revival**. Slide example: **The Animals, "The House of the Rising Sun" (1964)** — an old American folk song, played by a British band with electric guitar and organ.

The name came from the press. "Folk rock" was the **U.S. music press describing the Byrds**. Same pattern as "hillbilly," "race" and "Rhythm and Blues" — the category is invented from outside, after the music exists.

"Mr. Tambourine Man" — two versions

	Bob Dylan	The Byrds
Release	On ***Bringing It All Back Home*** (1965)	**Debut single, Columbia Records** (1965)
Sound	Dylan's own folk version	**Rock beat, strong melody, vocal harmonies, 12-string Rickenbacker**, surrealist/poetic influences
Who plays	Dylan	**The Wrecking Crew — minus McGuinn's guitar**

The Byrds' version is the slides' example of the **evolving "California Sound" (ambition, maturity)**.

Two things to notice:

- **The 12-string Rickenbacker** — Week 4.1's guitar table listed Rickenbacker as the chiming, jangly guitar of the Byrds and Beatles. This is the record that made it famous.
- **The Wrecking Crew again.** On their own debut single, the Byrds were mostly replaced by session musicians; only Roger McGuinn's guitar is his. The same question as *Pet Sounds* and "He's a Rebel": the name on the record isn't always who played it.

Dylan connection for the midterm. *Bringing It All Back Home* (1965) is also the album that opens with **"Subterranean Homesick Blues"** — the Dylan song on your list. The album is where Dylan moves from acoustic folk to electric rock.

Urban Folk, Bob Dylan and Newport 1965 (Week 6.2)

Folk before the revival. Folk had a long history before its resurgence in the late 1950s and early 1960s. The slides frame folk as a set of debates about its politics and use:

- Left vs. right
- Authenticity vs. change
- Preservation vs. transformation

Five characteristics of folk (Ronald Cohen)

1. Origins in a particular culture or region
2. Authorship has historically been unknown
3. Traditionally performed by non-professionals
4. Simple, communal composition
5. Songs passed down through oral transmission

This is close to the opposite of Tin Pan Alley (Week 2), where named professional songwriters sold songs as sheet music. Dylan himself breaks points 2 and 3: he is a known professional writing his own songs.

Three figures before Dylan

Figure	Dates	Key points
Woody Guthrie	1912–1967	Added social commentary and protest to popular music; "This Land Is Your Land" (1944/45); Dylan's main influence
Pete Seeger	1919–2014	Supported union organizing (1930s–40s); member of the Communist Party; influential politically and musically
Barbara Dane	b. 1927	Folk and political activism; anti-war coffeehouse circuit; "I Hate the Capitalist System" (1973, Paredon/Folkways), linked on the slide to Sarah Ogan Gunning's "I Hate the Company Bosses" (Library of Congress, 1938; *Girl of Constant Sorrow*, 1965)

Bob Dylan's early career

- Arrives in **Greenwich Village (New York) in 1961**
- Debut album ***Bob Dylan* (1962)**: a **Robert Shelton review in the *New York Times*** and a **contract with Columbia Records**; relied on pre-existing folk material; influenced by **Woody Guthrie**

- His songs fit the **protest** genre but were **more abstract** than direct protest songs:
  - "Blowin' in the Wind" (1963), on *The Freewheelin' Bob Dylan*
  - "Don't Think Twice, It's All Right" (1963), which the slide links to the March on Washington

"Subterranean Homesick Blues" (1965, Columbia) — *on the midterm song list*

- On ***Bringing It All Back Home*** (1965)
- Seen as a **threat to the aesthetic and political beliefs of the folk movement**
- **Rock 'n' roll beat + surreal lyrics** influenced by the **Beat poets**
- **Listen for:** rapid-fire, half-spoken vocals over an electric band; harmonica breaks

"Like a Rolling Stone" (1965): the slide's point is the **organ and electric guitar**.

Newport Folk Festival, 1965

- Took place during the **"folk-rock" craze**
- Dylan's **first live, plugged-in performance**, labelled a **"defection"**
- Backed by the **Butterfield Blues Band**; the slide's song is **"Maggie's Farm"**
- Folk purists objected to three things: **the electric guitar, using a rock 'n' roll band, and performing a single**
- **Brackett (156):** the crowd was split. Most fell silent after his songs, a few booed "their once-and-former idol," and others cheered and heard the new Dylan as speaking for them.

Electric folk: why it matters

- Dylan's move to electric guitar **reinforced the value and meaning of the guitar for the rock decade**
- It **shifted the relationship between sound and noise, and between lyric and rhythm**, and changed what a listening audience would accept
- Course link: the **authenticity** argument from Week 1 now happens *inside* folk. The electric guitar, rock's symbol of power in Week 4, means selling out to folk purists.

Soul, Motown and Aretha Franklin (Week 6.3)

Soul as "Southern music." In the slides, "Southern" means more than geography. It stands for an **ideology of disconnection**, a history of **displacement and oppression**, and **narratives of Black America**. Example: **Sam Cooke, "A Change Is Gonna Come" (1964)**.

"Soul music" as a term

- Enters mainstream usage in the 1960s
- **Cuts ties with 1950s rhythm and blues**, marking a distinct 1960s "soul" genre
- Another genre label that marks a break, like "race" giving way to "Rhythm and Blues" (Week 3)

Stax vs. Motown

	Stax	Motown
City	Memphis	Detroit
Style	"Down-home," "Southern" soul	Northern, "smooth" or "uptown" soul
Artists	Otis Redding, Booker T. & the MG's, Sam & Dave	The Supremes, Four Tops, Temptations, Stevie Wonder

Motown Records

- Founded by **Berry Gordy in Detroit, 1959**, **inspired by the assembly line**
- **Moved to Los Angeles in 1972**
- By the mid-1960s, the **most successful U.S. business owned by an African American**
- **The "Motown Sound":** stereotypically "sweet" and "pop," though it ranged from pop (the Supremes) to funk (Junior Walker). Typical features: **tambourine accenting the backbeat**; **orchestral strings, horns and background vocals**; the rule **KISS ("Keep It Simple, Stupid")**
- Compare **the Brill Building** (Week 5): a factory model with songwriters and producers in control. The difference is that Motown was Black-owned.

Holland–Dozier–Holland (HDH)

- The songwriting and production trio that **helped define the Motown sound**
- **1962–1967** was Motown's prime: **25 No. 1 singles**
- **1967: a dispute with Gordy over royalties.** It is the credit-and-payment issue again.

The Funk Brothers. Motown's house band of session musicians (the slide is a photo only). Compare the Wrecking Crew (Week 5) and the Nashville A-Team (Week 3).

The Supremes, "You Keep Me Hangin' On" (1966, Motown) — *on the midterm song list*

- Written and produced by **HDH**, played by **the Funk Brothers**

- A **distinct guitar part** that sounds like **Morse code or a radio broadcast**
- **Multitrack production**, influenced by the **Wall of Sound**
- **Widely covered**: **Vanilla Fudge** made a notable version
- **Listen for:** the Morse-code guitar pulse right from the start, with Diana Ross on lead

Aretha Franklin

- Born **1942, Memphis**; **gospel** roots; **"The Queen of Soul"**
- Commercial success with **Atlantic Records**
- Linked soul music to **political engagement** and a **growing African American middle class**

"Respect" (1967, Atlantic) — *on the midterm song list*

- **Produced by Jerry Wexler**
- **Originally released by Otis Redding (1965)**, a Stax artist
- In Franklin's version it becomes **a woman's confidence, demanding a man's respect**
- A **symbol of the feminist movement**
- Connected to soul and **changing Black racial self-consciousness**
- **Listen for:** a gospel-trained power vocal, the spelled-out "R-E-S-P-E-C-T," and backing-vocal responses

Connections: Atlantic was Ray Charles's label, and gospel → soul is the line from Week 3. "Respect" is the strongest example of **female subjectivity** (Brabazon, Week 5): unlike the girl groups, Aretha was a star demanding something in her own voice.

Readings: "Good Vibrations" and "I Want to Hold Your Hand"

Questions can come from required readings. The Beach Boys are on the review sheet. The Beatles are not, so treat the Breihan chapter as lower priority.

Elias Leight, "Forever No. 1: The Beach Boys, 'Good Vibrations'" (*Billboard*, 2025)

- **The Beach Boys' third and last Hot 100 No. 1 masterminded by Brian Wilson**, after "I Get Around" and "Help Me, Rhonda" (1965). It was also their **first million-selling single**.
- **Released October 1966.** It entered the Hot 100 at No. 81 and **reached No. 1 in December**, replacing "Winchester Cathedral." It also went to No. 1 in the U.K.

- **Mike Love called it "truly radical."** It opens without drums, with **Carl Wilson** on lead, then shifts into a driving bass line and full harmonies. A whistling, tea-kettle sound comes from an **Electro-Theremin**. The song keeps switching between these moods.
- **Recorded in pieces.** Instead of one backing track, Brian recorded **short, unrelated fragments and pieced them together** ("like working with a vast jigsaw puzzle" — Love). He moved between **several L.A. studios** (Gold Star, Western, Sunset Sound, Columbia; some accounts add RCA Victor). The final mix went from **16-track down to mono**.
- **The accounts disagree:** six months or six weeks; about 15 or 22 sessions; a cost estimated at **$10,000–$50,000**. Leaf credits the **cello used as a rock instrument** to Van Dyke Parks, while Love credits Carl Wilson.
- **Session musicians:** drummer **Hal Blaine** (Wrecking Crew) said the players had no idea what the finished song would sound like.
- **R&B goal:** Wilson wanted "a taste of modern, avant-garde R&B" and once meant to sell the song to an R&B act.
- **Lyrics by Mike Love,** made up while driving to the session ("'excitations' is not really a word… But it rhymed").
- **Left off *Pet Sounds*.** *Pet Sounds* (May 1966) peaked at only **No. 10**, one of the band's weakest sellers. Al Jardine says leaving "Good Vibrations" off was a mistake, but **Brian had the say because he was the producer**.
- **Afterwards:** Brian moved on to ***Smile***, which he abandoned amid paranoia and drug use. "Good Vibrations" marks **the end of the Beach Boys as a commercially dominant group**.
- **Course links:** producer as auteur (Spector → Wilson); the studio as an instrument; the Wrecking Crew; art vs. commerce (*Pet Sounds*).

Tom Breihan, "The Beatles — 'I Want to Hold Your Hand'" (*The Number Ones*, pp. 35–48)

- **Released in the U.S. December 26, 1963; hit No. 1 February 1, 1964.**
- **Capitol**, EMI's U.S. subsidiary, at first refused to release Beatles singles. Earlier singles came out on small labels: **Vee-Jay** ("Please Please Me," "From Me to You") and **Swan**, the label **Dick Clark** co-founded ("She Loves You"). All three flopped.
- **A D.C. radio DJ played an imported copy**, so Capitol rush-released the single and pressed **a million copies over Christmas**. It also paid for a huge publicity campaign ("The Beatles are coming" stickers).

- **The *Ed Sullivan Show*:** watched by **73 million Americans (34% of the population)**. By April 1964, **the entire Hot 100 top five was Beatles songs**, a record not matched until Drake in 2021.
- **Background:** skiffle and trad jazz in late-1950s England → the Quarrymen (1957) → Merseybeat, the Cavern and Hamburg → Ringo replaces Pete Best. Manager **Brian Epstein**; turned down by Decca, signed by EMI. Producer **George Martin let them record their own Lennon–McCartney songs**, which was unusual at the time.
- **Not pretending to be American.** Lennon: "you just can't be American." Unlike the blues-focused Stones and Animals, the Beatles drew on **pop**: songwriting factories like **Aldon** (Brill Building), **girl-group records**, the Everly Brothers' harmonies and Buddy Holly. They sounded **fast, trebly and exuberant**: hand claps, two lead voices merging, a big beat.
- **Timing:** the band arrived weeks after **the Kennedy assassination**, when U.S. pop was dominated by tame teen idols. The chapter treats them as a burst of optimism ("a fling after the wake" — Lester Bangs).
- **The "imperial phase"** (Neil Tennant): an artist at an absolute peak. For the Beatles it lasted from 1964 to 1970, with **20 No. 1 hits**, still the record.
- **The British Invasion followed:** Peter and Gordon; **the Animals' "House of the Rising Sun" (No. 1, Sept. 1964)**; Manfred Mann's "Do Wah Diddy Diddy," a **Brill Building song (Barry–Greenwich) that had flopped for the Exciters, a Black girl group**, became a No. 1 hit for a British band. British bands copied American blues, and American teens treated the British bands as exotic: a two-way exchange.
- **Writing your own songs became the norm.** Bands that relied on outside songwriters looked weak by comparison, as when **the Monkees fought Don Kirshner** (Aldon) to stop being "pop puppets." The acts that kept thriving (Stones, Beach Boys, Supremes and Motown) were the ones that rose to the Beatles' challenge.
- **Course links:** Dick Clark (Week 5); Phil Spector (sat next to McCartney on the flight to New York); Brill Building and girl groups; the Animals (Week 6.1); "who is the author?"

*The PDF also includes the first page of Breihan's next chapter, on **the Supremes' "Where Did Our Love Go" (released June 1964, No. 1 August 22, 1964)**. Its opening sound is a studio gofer's shoes stamping on a wooden floor.*

How Week 6 Connects Back

Week 6 material	Earlier week	The connection
"Surfin' U.S.A." from Berry's "Sweet Little Sixteen" → songwriting credit	Week 4 — "Hound Dog," "That's All Right"; Week 2 — appropriation	A white group's hit built on a Black artist's song; here the credit was corrected
"Chuck Berry riffs" in the Beach Boys' sound	Week 4 — Chuck Berry's guitar	Berry's guitar style becomes the template for 1960s rock
Brian Wilson and the "Spector sound"; Wall of Sound on "Wouldn't It Be Nice"	Week 5 — Phil Spector	The producer-as-auteur model passes from Spector to Wilson
The Wrecking Crew on *Pet Sounds* and the Byrds' debut	Week 5 — Wrecking Crew; Week 3 — Nashville A-Team	Session musicians standing in for the named band
"Brian Wilson's puppets?"	Week 5 — "replaceable performers"	Who is the author of a record?
Studio experimentation, concept album	Week 4.2 lecture — rock 'n' roll → rock through studio technology	The shift the lecture predicted
Financial vs critical success	Week 1 — art vs commerce	*Pet Sounds* as "art" that sold less
"Folk rock" named by the U.S. music press	Week 2/3 — hillbilly, race, Rhythm and Blues	Genre labels come from outside the music
12-string Rickenbacker on "Mr. Tambourine Man"	Week 4.1 — guitar table	The Byrds' signature jangle
Dylan going electric at Newport (1965)	Week 1 — authenticity	Authenticity fight inside folk
Motown's assembly-line model; HDH royalty dispute	Week 5 — Brill Building	Same model, Black-owned
"Respect" and soul; Aretha on Atlantic	Week 3 — Ray Charles, gospel → soul, soul and civil rights	The lecture's promised return to soul

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Surf music	Early-60s Southern California youth music; initially instrumental, built on trebly electric guitar
California Sound	The Beach Boys' harmonies plus Wilson's production; later the Byrds' more ambitious version
Contrapuntal	Several independent vocal lines at once
Concept album	An album conceived as one connected work (*Pet Sounds*)
Overdubbing	Recording extra parts on top of existing tracks
Looping	Repeating a recorded segment
Folk rock	Traditional folk + rock instrumentation; a term coined by the U.S. press for the Byrds
Urban folk revival	Late-50s/early-60s resurgence of folk, debated over politics (left vs. right), authenticity vs. change, preservation vs. transformation
Motown	Berry Gordy's Detroit label (1959), modelled on the assembly line; most successful Black-owned U.S. business by the mid-1960s
Cohen's five characteristics	Folk = regional/cultural origin, unknown authorship, non-professional performers, simple communal composition, oral transmission
Electric folk	Dylan's move to electric guitar; made the guitar central to the rock decade and shifted sound/noise and lyric/rhythm
Soul music	Distinct 1960s genre that cuts ties with 1950s R&B; "Southern" as an ideology and narratives of Black America
Stax	Memphis label; "down-home," Southern soul (Otis Redding, Booker T. & the MG's, Sam & Dave)

Term	Definition
Motown Sound	"Sweet," pop-leaning soul: tambourine on the backbeat, strings, horns, background vocals; KISS
Holland–Dozier–Holland	Motown writing/production trio; 25 No. 1s in 1962–67; royalty dispute with Gordy in 1967
The Funk Brothers	Motown's in-house session band

Listening List

Track	Artist	Year	Label	Listen for
"Walk, Don't Run"	The Ventures	1960/64	—	Instrumental surf guitar
"Misirlou"	Dick Dale	1962	—	Fast tremolo-picked guitar
"Surfin' U.S.A."	**The Beach Boys**	**1963**	**Capitol**	Berry guitar intro; stacked harmonies, falsetto; surf-spot lyrics
"Wouldn't It Be Nice"	**The Beach Boys**	**1966**	**Capitol**	Chiming intro; orchestral layers; overdubbed vocals; key change
"The House of the Rising Sun"	The Animals	1964	—	Folk song with electric guitar and organ
"Mr. Tambourine Man"	Bob Dylan / The Byrds	1965	Columbia (Byrds)	Compare acoustic Dylan with the Byrds' 12-string Rickenbacker
"Subterranean Homesick Blues"	**Bob Dylan**	**1965**	**Columbia**	Rapid half-spoken vocals, electric band, harmonica
"You Keep Me Hangin' On"	**The Supremes**	**1966**	**Motown**	Morse-code guitar figure; Diana Ross lead

Track	Artist	Year	Label	Listen for
"Respect"	**Aretha Franklin**	**1967**	**Atlantic**	Gospel power vocal; "R-E-S-P-E-C-T"; backing-vocal responses
"This Land Is Your Land"	Woody Guthrie	1944/45	—	Folk with social commentary
"Blowin' in the Wind"	Bob Dylan	1963	Columbia	Acoustic guitar and harmonica; abstract protest lyric
"Like a Rolling Stone"	Bob Dylan	1965	Columbia	Organ and electric guitar
"Maggie's Farm" (Newport)	Bob Dylan + Butterfield Blues Band	1965	—	Loud electric blues-rock band at a folk festival
"A Change Is Gonna Come"	Sam Cooke	1964	—	Orchestral soul ballad; civil-rights era

Bold = on the midterm song list.

Self-Check

- [ ] Name two features of surf music before the Beach Boys, with one example
- [ ] List the four features of the Beach Boys' sound from the slides
- [ ] Explain the "Sweet Little Sixteen" songwriting credit and connect it to an earlier week
- [ ] Give three studio techniques used on *Pet Sounds* and explain the "financial vs critical success" point
- [ ] Explain the "Brian Wilson's puppets?" question
- [ ] Give five features of "Wouldn't It Be Nice" from the slides
- [ ] Define folk rock and say who named it
- [ ] Compare Dylan's and the Byrds' "Mr. Tambourine Man"
- [ ] Explain what Dylan did at Newport 1965 and the three things folk purists objected to
- [ ] Describe the Motown model and the Motown Sound, and compare Motown with Stax

- [ ] Explain how Aretha changed the meaning of "Respect": who wrote it first, who produced her version, what it came to symbolize
- [ ] List Ronald Cohen's five characteristics of folk
- [ ] Give three facts about "You Keep Me Hangin' On" from the slides (who made it, the guitar part, the production)